

CHAPTER 3

THE PLOT THICKENS

'You sold the drawings of our rocket engines to Pakistan.'

The Hindustan Latex Guest House at Poojappura, Trivandrum, was a nice place where Intelligence Bureau guys had great fun interrogating the dodgiest of suspects. I was given a spacious, air-conditioned room on the first floor, with a bed in a corner and a small teapoy in the middle. Great comfort for an accused, I thought. But something seemed amiss: usually the telephone in guest houses, as in hotels, is kept by the bed. Here it was on the teapoy in the middle of the room.

A constable, supposed to be my guard, walked in. I asked him what was going on. He kept mum. He put a finger across his mouth, gesturing me not to speak. When I again asked him, he repeated the gesture, this time with a 'shhh …'.

Through gestures he told me that the place was bugged. Now the telephone in the middle of the room made sense. There was a microphone under it. The constable, who later identified himself as Anil, was courteous.

Half an hour later he took me downstairs. It was the customary photo session for the accused. They clicked four photographs—two from the front and one from each side. One of the profile shots soon appeared in some Malayalam dailies. After the photo session, I was made to sit in a room on the ground floor.

A circle inspector whose name I later learnt was Charles, an acquaintance of my ISRO colleague John George, appeared briefly. He